

Unit-III

Understanding Harmony in the Family and Society- Harmony in Human-Human Relationship

In the previous units, we studied about harmony in the human being. The next level is with the family.

1. Understanding values in human-human relationship

Family is a basic unit of human interaction: Each one of us is naturally a part of a family that includes father, mother, brothers and sisters. Then there are other relations such as grandparents, relatives from father side and mother side, etc., These relations are a reality of our life for each one of us. We are born in these relationships. Then we also have friends, colleagues with whom we frequently interact. So starting from our family, including our teachers, friends and all the different social relationships, each one of us is born and lives in such relationships. This is an indivisible part of our living.

Harmony in the family: Here is a set of proposal for you to verify:

1. Relationship is between 'I' and 'I'
2. The self ('I') has feeling in a relationship. These feelings are between 'I' and 'I'
3. These feeling in the self ('I') are definite. They can be identified with definiteness
4. Recognizing and fulfilling these feelings leads to mutual happiness in a relationship.

Explanation for each of the above

1. **Relationship is between 'I' and 'I':** We saw that we inherently are in relationship with each other. Little exploration will reveal that it is the person's self which is primarily related to the other person's self. The body is only a means to express or receive our relationship. As we discussed in the earlier, the human being is co-existence of the Self ('I') and the Body. The body is incapable of understanding as well as having feelings. It is the self ('I') that recognizes the relationship. Thus, a relationship exists between self ('I') and the other self ('I').
The relation to the body is through the self ('I'). **For example:** a mother feels related to the child she has given birth to. But neither mother's body nor the child's has feelings. It is the self of the mother and the child who feel connected.
2. **The self ('I') has feeling in a relationship. these feelings are between 'I' and 'I':** There are feeling in relations naturally. They do not have to be created nor we remove. The feelings are fundamental to the relationship and can be recognized. Now let's ask some questions:
Q: Who has these feelings? I or body?
A: I
Q: With whom does I have these feelings? with the other I or the other Body
A: With the other I
Q: Who wants trust in relationship? You or the Body?
A: I want trust
Q: From whom do you want this trust? The other I or Body?
A: From the other I

This is something you can easily verify yourself, that it is I that wants trust. When you respect someone, you respect the person, 'I' and not their body organs! When you trust someone, it is the person and not the body. Finally, the feelings in relationship are between 'I' and 'I'.

3. **These feeling in the self ('I') are definite. They can be identified with definiteness:**
We have already seen that relationship is naturally there between humans, that this relationship is between 'I' and 'I' and that there are feelings in the relationship. The feelings in relationship are to be identified with clarity.
With little exploration, we can see that feelings in relationships are actually definite. These are the values characterizing relationships- examples: trust, respect, affection, etc.,
4. **Recognizing and fulfilling these feelings leads to mutual happiness in a relationship:** Once we have recognizes the existence of human relationships, we are subsequently able to identify the feelings (values). When we work and behave according to these feelings, it leads to fulfillment of both sides in the relationship, i.e., it leads to mutual fulfillment. Evaluation is a natural process when we live in relationships and we are constantly evaluating our's and the other's feelings in the relationship. For example: Trust is wanted in a relationship and if there is a mutual feeling of trust, then it leads to mutual fulfillment and there are no complaints. But if there is doubt on the other, the happiness in relationship is missing.

Irrespective of any mutual differences between different family members, certain traditional values meticulously cherished over the centuries always keep families united together.

1. **The sense of belonging:** When a child was enrolled in a school, he/she gets identified by a specific name, but just a physical body with a name is not enough.

So in the school register they write 'so and so', son/ daughter of 'so and so' followed by postal address. With no time, the child gets three more identities he/she belongs to a name, father's name and an address. In this manner every 'I' continues adding several such identities to his/her original identity throughout his/her life.

This sense of belonging to a father, a family and a school or a town or a country is responsible for developing an instant attachment to all those identities. Such attachment to a specific family is a great tool for maintaining harmony with that family.

2. **The bond of love:** A self loving 'I' also naturally loves everything that belongs to him. A mother loves her child because it is an extension of her own physical body and it belongs to her. The bond of love is another great tool that ensures harmony in the family and makes everyone stick to the family throughout the life.

A small child cries at any odd hour of the night, urinates and defecates at any place at any time causing lack of sleep, rest and discomfort to his/her mother. It is the none of love that makes a mother look after the child dutifully in spite of all the discomfort

without any complaining. Every mother and father want their child to stay healthy, well provided for and also grow and prosper in his/her life.

So, whenever someone is unhappy with a member of the family, he/she should first think of his sense of belonging to that person and also the bond of love that existed between the two.

3. **The bond of unity:** Imagine a small family of four persons, father, mother, son and daughter. Though they remain bound together due to a natural bond of love and interdependence, individually all of them may possibly carry some small complaints against each other. The man may want his wife to look after the household more efficiently, cook tastier food, be less demanding. He also may want both his children to do better academically and always be obedient.

Similarly, mother, may want her husband to earn far more than his current income, help her willingly in her household chores. Children could also possibly want their parents to be more liberal, considerate and always attentive to their needs.

If a person (family head or income earning person) fulfils his needs he is happy but if he does not then he is unhappy. Such unhappiness expresses itself in the form of complaints and arguments. If a neighbor enters into that argument, then all the four fighting members of the family spontaneously unite into one family.

No wonder, the sense of belonging to each other and the bond of natural love between them integrated as one family. Understanding of oneness with the family is responsible for maintaining perfect harmony within the family.

4. **The bond of duty:** Every member has the right to expect cooperation from the rest of the family in his progress and fulfillment and every member is bound by certain duties and obligations which must be fulfilled. A family is conglomerate of various members belonging to different age groups, preferences, likes and dislikes. It is not possible to discuss all the needs of all the members of a family and their corresponding duties towards each other but discussing one primary duty of every person will bring enough clarity in this matter.

Every person is indebted to his parents for his existence in this world. His mother carries the child in her womb for 9 months to nurture his unborn body. After his birth, his parents look after his every need as he is unable to do anything for himself. They (parents) lovingly clean him, feed him, teach him to walk, talk, the entire process entails a story of 18 long years of selfless service. During this period, the pains they undergo are for the child and the pleasure they experience are also for the child.

No one can ever repay this debt back to his parents and other elders as this relationship is not mutually replaceable. However the only way to get redemption from this debt is to offer similar selfless service with smile to all the members of the family, especially to parents when they need support from yourself.

5. **The bond of acceptance:** In a family, there are two brothers who always fight with each other for some or the other reason, may be because they do not like each other's

attitude. It is not possible for them to avoid each other because being brothers, they live in the same family. No one can ever think of changing a brother as it is a default relationship.

Parents can do nothing more than mediating in their disputes. Both of them being their sons, they can't do anything. So, here is a situation where one does not like his brother but he can neither avoid him nor change him. In this situation, they are having only two options, either leave the parents and household or accept his brother.

The first alternative is out of question as both of them depend on their parents. What they can only do is to accept each other as they are. Though they accepted each other apparently, they still hated each other from within. Most unfortunately they did not learn the true meaning of acceptance.

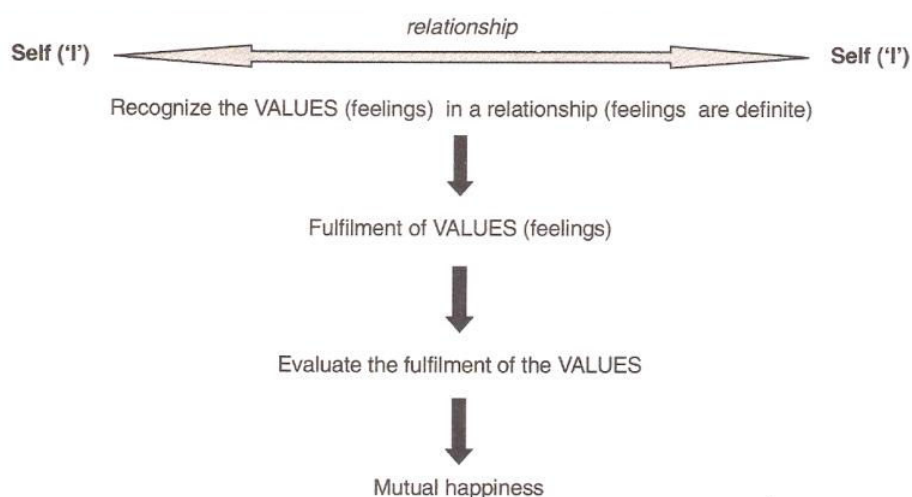
There are many other bonds like trust, respect and understanding etc., which helps to maintain harmony within a family.

2. Meaning of Justice (Nine universal values in relationships) and Program for its fulfillment to ensure mutual happiness

Justice (Nyaya): Justice is the recognition of values (the definite feelings in a relationship, their fulfillment, the right evaluation of the fulfillment resulting in mutual happiness.

Justice concerns itself with the proper ordering of things and people within a society. There are four elements: Recognition of values, fulfillment, evaluation and mutual happiness ensured. When all the four are ensured, justice is ensured. Mutual fulfillment is the hallmark of justice. And justice is essential in all relationships. Justice starts from the family and slowly expands to the world family. The child gets an understanding of justice in the family. With this understanding, he goes out into society and interacts with people.

The process of ensuring justice has been outlined in the diagram below:



If the understanding of justice is ensured in the family, there will be justice in all the interactions we have in the world at large. If we do not understand the values in relationships, we are governed by our petty prejudices and conditionings. We may treat people as high or low based on their body (particular caste, or sex or race or tribe), on the basis of wealth one possesses or the belief systems that one follows.

All this is a source of injustice and leads to a fragmented society while our natural acceptance is for an undivided society and universal human order. Having explored the harmony in human beings, we are able to explore the harmony in the family. This enables us to understand the harmony at the level of society and nature/existence. And this is the way the harmony in our living grows. We slowly get the competence to live in harmony with all human beings.

Nine universal values in relationships: There are nine feelings (values), or expectation of feelings (values), in relationship. These feelings (values) can be recognized, they are definite (9 Feelings), their fulfilment and evaluation leads to mutual happiness.

Trust	Respect	Affection
Care	Guidance	Reverence
Glory	Gratitude	Love

1. Trust (Vishvas): Trust is the foundational value in relationship. Trust means “**To be assured that the other wants to make me happy and prosperous**” is known as trust.

Trust is the expectation of people that they can rely on our word. It is built through integrity and consistency in relationships. To keep the trust on ourself and others, we have to pay attention on the intentions and to understand if we or the other person is not able to do benefit, it is because we are lacking competence. Trust is the result of right understanding of the intention of all the human beings around us.

2. Respect (Sammana): Respect is right evaluation of each other's intention (=Natural acceptance) and competence. The sense of individuality is prime object. This is the first basic step towards respect (Sammana). Once we realized that we are individual then only we can see ourself different from others. In other words, respect means right evaluation, to be evaluated as I am.

3. Affection (Sneha): Affection is the feeling of being related to the other. Affection comes when I recognize that we both want to make each other happy and both of us are similar. Then for the first time, I feel that I am related to the other that the other is a relative of mine. This feeling is called affection. The feeling of affection comes only if trust and respect are already ensured. Without trust and respect, we feel the other is trying to make us unhappy. We always see the other as being in opposition.

4. Care (Mamata): Care is the feeling to nurture and protect the body of my relative with the help of physical facilities. Care is level of active concern or lack of negligence towards avoidance of possible dangers, mistakes and risks.

We understand a human being as a coexistence of the self ('I') and the body, and the body is an instrument of 'I'. Based on this understanding, we take the responsibility of nurturing and protecting the body of our relatives.

5. Guidance (*Vatsalya*): Guidance is the feeling of responsibility and commitment for ensuring right understanding and right feeling in the self of my relative. We understand the need of self ('I') for right understanding and feelings. We also understand that the other is similar to me in his/her faculty of natural acceptance, desire of wanting continuous happiness and the program of living in harmony at all the four levels. The other is also similar to me in the potential of desire, thoughts and expectation.

6. Reverence (*Shraddha*): The feeling of acceptance of excellence in the other is called reverence. We understand that we aspire for continuous happiness and to realize it, we have to understand harmony at all the levels of our living, and live accordingly.

When we see that the other has achieved this excellence- which means to understand and to live in harmony at all the levels of living ensuring continuity of happiness, we have a feeling of reverence for him/her. This feeling of accepting the excellence in the other is called reverence.

7. Glory(*Guarava*): Glory is the feeling for someone who has made efforts for excellence. We find that there have been people in the history or even around us, who are investing their time, energy and their belongings to achieve excellence (to understand and to live in harmony at all levels of living ensuring continuity of happiness), to make others excellent. This gives us a feeling of glory for them.

8. Gratitude (*Kritagyata*): Gratitude is the feeling of acceptance for those who have made efforts for my excellence. Gratitude is an emotion that occurs after people receive help, depending on how they interpret the situation. Specifically, gratitude is experienced if people perceive the help they receive as (a) valuable to them, (b) costly to their benefactor and (c) given by the benefactor with benevolent intentions.

9. Love (*Prema*): Love is the feeling of being related to all. Love is complete value. It starts with identifying that one is related to the other human being and it slowly expands to the feeling of being related to all human beings. Love is expressed in the form of kindness, beneficence and compassion. Love is the basis of undivided society and universal human order.

Thus, we can conclude that, the family is a laboratory of sorts, in which we live our understanding and relationships. On getting assured, it becomes easy to see that society is an extension of family and it is possible to live in harmony with every human being.

3. Trust and Respect as the foundational values of relationship

Trust (*Vishwas*) and Respect (*Samman*) are two of the most fundamental values that form the foundation of healthy relationships, whether they are personal or professional. In this course, we will explore the meaning of these values, the ways in which they contribute to the well-being of individual and relationships and how to cultivate these values in personal and professional contexts.

Trust is defined as a belief in the reliability, truth, ability or strength of someone or something. In relationships, trust is the foundation that allows individuals to feel confident and secure in their interactions with each other. When trust is present in a relationship, individuals are able to be vulnerable, share personal information and rely on each other. On the other hand, when trust is absent, individuals tend to be guarded and relationships can become strained, filled with misunderstandings and lack a sense of connection.

Respect, on the other hand, is defined as a feeling of admiration and reverence for someone or something. In relationships, respect involves valuing the thoughts, opinions and feelings of others and treating them with dignity and kindness. When respect is present in relationship, individuals feel valued and appreciated with fosters a positive and supportive environment. In contrast, when respect is absent, individuals can feel unheard, disrespected and dismissed, which can lead to conflicts and breakdowns in the relationship.

The combination of trust and respect in a relationship creates an safe environment and support, where individuals can be their authentic selves and freely express themselves without fear of judgment or rejection. This type of relationship provides individual with a sense of connection and belonging and allows them to grow and develop as individuals.

In order to cultivate trust and respect in personal relationships, it is important to consistently communicate with each other, listen actively and make an effort to understand the perspectives and needs of others. Additionally, it is important to practice honest, transparency and accountability as these behaviours demonstrate a commitment to the relationship and build trust over time.

4. Difference between Intention and Competence

Intention and **competence** are two distinct but related concepts that play a crucial role in shaping personal and professional outcomes. **Intention is what one aspires for and competence is the ability to fulfil the aspiration.**

Intentions (Wanting to our natural acceptance) is an important factor is shaping personal and professional outcomes, as it provides a sense of direction and purpose and helps individuals to focus their efforts and resources. Intention can take many forms, ranging from personal goals such as improving one's health or relationships to professional goals such as advancing in one's career or starting a business.

Competence (Being able to do), on the other hand refers to the skills, knowledge and abilities required to effectively achieve one's intentions. Competence encompasses a wide range of personal and professional skills such as technical skills, communication skills, leadership skills and interpersonal skills.

The relationship between intention and competence is complex and dynamic. In order to achieve one's intention, individuals must possess the necessary competence but at the same time developing competence often requires individuals to set and pursue intentional goals.

For example: In order to become a successful professional in particular field, individuals must first have the intention to pursue that career and then develop necessary skills, knowledge and abilities through education and training.

Thus, intention and competence are two important and interrelated factors that shape personal and professional outcomes. While intention provides a sense of direction and purpose, competence is essential for effectively achieving one's goals. By setting intentional goals and developing the necessary competence, individual can promote positive and fulfilling outcomes in their personal and professional lives.

Evaluating Trust – Between 2 Individuals	
About your Natural Acceptance	About your Ability
1a. I want to make myself happy ✓	1b. I am able to make myself always happy ?
2a. I want to make the other happy ✓	2b. I am able to make the other always happy ?
3a. The other wants to make herself/himself happy ✓	3b. The other is able to make herself/himself always happy ?
4a. The other wants to make me happy ?	4b. The other is able to make me always happy ??
<u>Intention – Natural Acceptance</u>	<u>Competence</u>
What is Naturally Acceptable to You	What You Are (Σ D, T, E)

About your Natural Acceptance	About your Ability
1a. I want to make myself happy ✓	1b. I am able to make myself always happy ?
2a. I want to make the other happy ✓	2b. I am able to make the other always happy ?
3a. The other wants to make herself/himself happy ✓	3b. The other is able to make herself/himself always happy ?
4a. The other wants to make me happy ?	4b. The other is able to make me always happy ??
<u>Intention – Natural Acceptance</u>	<u>Competence</u>
What is Naturally Acceptable to You	What You Are (Σ D, T, E)

If you see this carefully you will realize that when you are judging *yourself* you are judging on the basis of your *intension*, whereas, when you are judging *the other* you are judging him on the basis of his *competence*. You are sure in point **2a** that you want to make the other happy, but in point **4a** you are not sure that the other wants to make you happy. We find that while we look at our intention, we are sure of it, we are not sure for other's intention. We are actually seeing their competence and making a conclusion on their intention.

Here is an example to better understand about the difference between intention and competence: Assume you are walking in your college campus and your close friend walks by from the other direction. You look at him and smiled but your friend doesn't noticed. You feel angry and disappointed that he didn't acknowledge your presence. You tent to assume that he wants to ignore you. Later on, you find out that he was disturbed since he had lost his wallet. You immediately feel alright and you are not angry anymore.

What happened here? You doubted your friend's *intention*. It is not that he **intended** to or wanted to ignore you, only that he was *preoccupied with something else*. However, you *doubted his intention* and for that instant, you felt a sense of *opposition for him* not a feeling of *relationship*. When you found out later on that he has lost his wallet, you immediately realized that it was *not his intention to ignore you, only his competence was lacking at that moment*.

The problem today is that even in families, we doubt each other with the result that we behave like enemies, we try to put the other person down and there is a breakdown of relationship. If trust, *the foundational value* is shaken then the whole relationship is disturbed. Trust comes from having the right understanding of the intention of every human being. When I have the right understanding, I end up becoming and aid to the understanding. Thus, with the right understanding not only am I fine at all times, I am also working to help others also be like me.

5. Understanding the meaning of Respect

Respect means "**Right Evaluation**" to be evaluated as I am. Usually we make mistakes in our evaluation in three ways.

- a) **Over evaluation:** Example: You are sitting at home and there are guests around. Your father says "my son/ daughter is the greatest scholar in India!" Check yourself; do you feel comfortable or do you feel uncomfortable?
- b) **Under evaluation:** Example: You are still at home, but this time you father says "My son/ daughter is good for nothing. He/she must be the laziest person in India!" You obviously feel uncomfortable, you don't find this acceptable.
- c) **Otherwise evaluation:** You are at home and there are guests around and your father says, " You donkey! Can't you even understand this much?" You feel offended by this. This is evaluating you otherwise as you are a human being and not something else.

What is happening in all these examples? We can see that any kind of over, under or otherwise evaluation makes us uncomfortable, we find it unacceptable. We feel 'disrespected'. We say we have been disrespected, when we are wrongly evaluated.

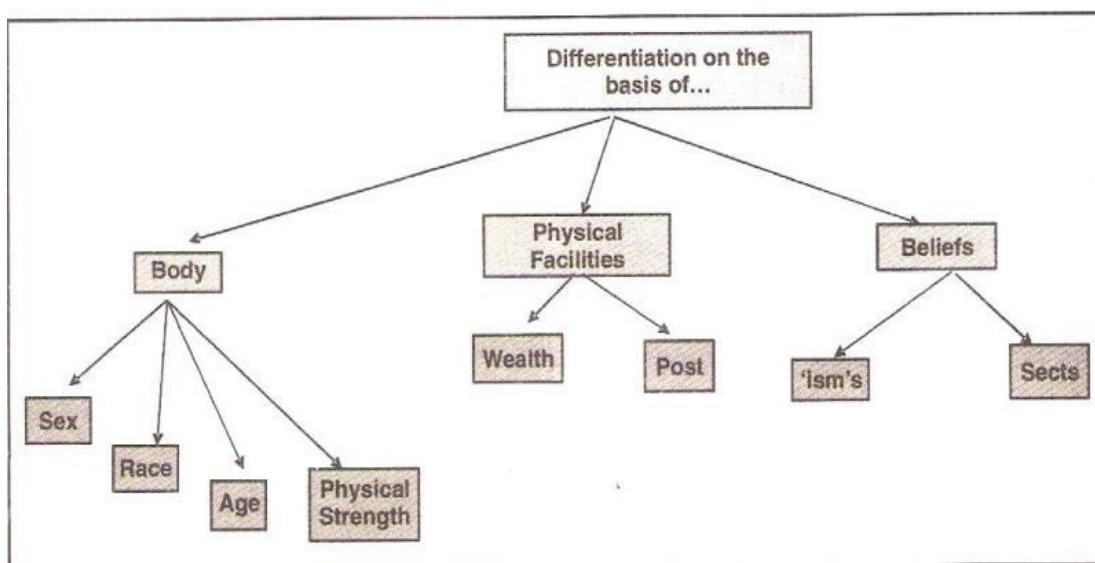
Thus, respect means to rightly evaluate. Can you think of the number of instances when you feel you have been wrongly evaluated and the number of times you may have done the same to others? You would be surprised to find this happens very often and we are insensitive about this aspect in relationship. Even though it is the cause of many problems for us in relationship, we ignore the point about respect.

We also have many different notations about respect that we currently hold as individuals and as a society. For example: Saluting someone is called respecting someone today. We even fire guns in the air after people are dead, as a mark of respect. Similarly, big buildings, good clothing, we dress up, different haircuts, mobile phones, bikes, cars, etc., lot of things are going on in the world in search for respect.

6. Difference between Respect and Differentiation

I. ASSUMED BASIS FOR RESPECT TODAY: Our basis for respect today is largely quite contrary to our discussion above. Instead of respect being a basis of similarity or one of right evaluation, we have made it into something on the basis of which we differentiate i.e. by respecting you, mean you are doing something special because you are special or have something special or are in some special position. Thus, all of us are running around seeking respect from one another by trying to become something special.

Today, we are **differentiating** in the name of **respect**. We either differentiate people on the basis of their **body**, on the basis of their **wealth** and **possessions**, or on the basis of their **beliefs**. There is no notion of respect in terms of right evaluation. Thus, there is no real feeling of *relationship*, only one of *differentiation*.



1. On the basis of body

- a) **Gender:** We have such notions as, respect males more than females, or even the other way round in some societies. We ignore the fact that being male or female is an attribute of the body and not an attribute at the level of 'I'. In many countries, people even prefer a male child to a female child, and in some other societies, the other way round.
- b) **Race:** If the person is of the same race as oneself, then we treat them differently. For example, we differentiate on the basis of skin colour – white, brown, black etc., or on the basis of caste, taking some caste to be high, the other to be low. Again here, we don't do the evaluation on the basis of 'I', but on the basis of the body- the colour of the skin or the race or the caste of the body.
- c) **Age:** We have notions such as 'one must respect elders'. What about youngsters? Should we insult them? Should we not respect them as well? Here again we are evaluating at the level of the body – age is related to the body and not to 'I'.
- d) **Physical strength:** If someone is stronger, we again treat him/her differently. This is again at the level of the body. In fact, we think that we are respecting the other while it is fear; the fear that if we do not treat them like this, we will be harmed.

2. On the basis of physical facilities

- a) **Wealth:** We differentiate people because some have more wealth than others. What we term as a "rich person" gets idolized. We don't even bother to find out whether such people are feeling prosperous or if they just have wealth? Are they happy, or just have wealth? – This is an evaluation on the basis of physical facilities. This way, we are over-evaluating physical facilities first, which are just meant to fulfil the needs of the body and then on this basis, we are wrongly identifying our relationship.
- b) **Post:** We try to respect on the basis of a person's position. Is this post directly related to the right understanding and feelings in the self? – We seldom verify. The post is wrongly evaluated as the mark of a person's excellence and differentiation sets in. The post is considered important either on the basis that it gives more physical facilities or on the basis that certain positions are assumed to be important! In our education, we are trained directly or indirectly to earn posts for us to fetch respect.

3. On the basis of beliefs

- a) **Isms:** Means any belief in terms of a *'thought system that we have'* or that we have adopted. There are also many modern 'isms' such as capitalism, socialism, communism, etc., The people following these sets of beliefs are called capitalists, socialists, communists, and so on. We only *have to look into this today* and we shall find countless such belief systems ... and the people that have adopted them or are following them have been exposed to them since childhood. Believing theirs to be the right belief. However, all beliefs, as we have seen are at the level of *desires, thoughts and expectations*. As we have already seen, there is *no definiteness at this level* and hence, this becomes a cause for differentiation.
- b) **Sects:** People of one sect only consider those with a similar belief system to be their 'own' and worthy of respect. Following a particular tradition, or what we call as religion, becomes the basis of respect and disrespect in relationship.

II. PROBLEMS DUE TO DIFFERENTIATION: Most of the problems in relationships manifests due to differentiation. We know that these problems have led to mass demonstrations and protests other kinds of movements by people around the world. This kind of differentiation, discrimination is not acceptable to them.

- i. **Differentiation based on sex/gender:** There are many movements in the world. For example: we have the issue of women's rights, women protesting and demanding for equality in education, in jobs and in people representation. As we discussed earlier, some people wants male children instead of girl. People are insecure and afraid of one another based on their gender.
- ii. **Differentiation based on race:** There are many movements and protest against racial discrimination and demands for equality. The movement against cast discrimination has been growing in India for over decades. Such discrimination leads to people living in fear of such racism.
- iii. **Differentiation based on age:** We hear of protests and movements demanding for equal rights for children on one hand and rights for elderly people on the other. One generation talks about being ignored by the other generation and this has become the source of tension in many families.
- iv. **Differentiation based on wealth:** This is an area that is increasingly becoming a very big area of differentiation and is leading all kinds of problems. (Rich countries and poor countries). We are not understanding the need for physical facilities and working for wealth to fetch respect. If the need for physical facilities is understood properly, we do not identify it with happiness. Many people suffering from a lack of self-esteem and some even committing suicide.

- v. **Differentiation based on post:** We see protest against high handed government officials because people feel they are being taken advantage of. This is due to the tremendous differentiation we make on the basis of position. If someone does not get or qualify for a post, they end up feeling that they will not get the respect in the society!
- vi. **Differentiation based on isms:** We all are quite aware of this differentiation on the basis of different thought systems. Communism for example. We even hear of people converting from one ism to another in order to be able to get more respect!
- vii. **Differentiation based on sects:** We all are aware of this. we have ended up making countless religions and sects. And each sect has its own movement to ensure that there is no discrimination against people of their belief. There are demands for provisions in jobs and in education based on religions and sects. Some of these protests and clashes between people of different beliefs even turn violent.

******End of Mid-I Syllabus******